

COU 5113
Case Study Analysis Assignment Form

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Section 1: Values, Power, Privileges, & Roles

As a future counselor in training, my personal values will play a crucial part in my thought process when counseling clients. However, it is important to acknowledge that one's own values, power, and privilege should not be intertwined with the clients' morals and/or values. Not being aware of this can possibly cause harm and countertransference could be possible. My personal values regarding marriage are centered in respect, loyalty, and commitment. Coming from a Hispanic cultural background, having a husband who is "a man of word" as my family would say is extremely important. My parents have always been vocal on loyalty and how the foundation of a relationship is built upon respect, honesty, and loyalty. In the case study in which the husband is actively cheating on his wife without her acknowledgement is challenging because I feel that my morals are being tested. I can understand how counseling this family and specifically the husband would require personal reflection and supervision to avoid damaging my client unintentionally.

In this scenario, I hold "power" by knowing information that could potentially damage the family. The husband used confidentiality as a manipulative tool by stating he was not going to tell me, then remembered that I cannot say anything to his wife because I must keep things confidential. This put me in a difficult situation when the wife has asked me "How were you able to help him so quickly?" because my response could have consequences to both parties. As for the privilege I possess, it allowed me to have training, resources, and supervisors I can consult with. However, having such privilege comes with responsibility to my profession and clients. Understanding that my decision will have an impact on every client is important. Having the privilege to understand confidentiality, its limits, and complexity play a huge role in counseling couples and families.

My role as a counselor is to respect confidentiality (within limitations), provide a safe space to clients, maintain a healthy therapeutic relationship, and avoid harm. Keeping in mind that I am a couple/family counselor, I must take into consideration the family unit. Seeking supervision to determine what is the best decision-making approach will help guide me through an evidence-based practice that will provide a framework. A huge role of mine is to consider the unhealthy coping mechanism the husband has found as an escape, the safety of the family, and the wife who is a victim of abuse and deception by her husband.

Section 2: Summary of Ethical Decision-Making Process, Decision, and Rationale

Confidentiality is a key role in counseling and the case study had an ethical dilemma regarding confidentiality within couples counseling. The husband engaged in affairs as a coping strategy where the wife was oblivious to his actions and congratulated the counselor on her husband's personal growth. He had a history of domestic violence but with his affairs, his anger was non-existent. The husband privately tells the counselor, she cannot disclose anything to his wife because of confidentiality with client and counselor relationships. According to ACA code of ethics, section B Couples and family counseling B.4.b the couple is the client and therefore, informed consent is important for the therapeutic alliance.

After carefully analyzing the case study I would implement an ethical decision-making process. Starting with, identifying the issue (confidentiality), involving client in the decision-making process (let the husband know of the steps going forward and the limitation of

confidentiality within couples and family), Acknowledging the nature and dimensions of the dilemma: breaking confidentiality from individual counseling versus fidelity and honesty in couples counseling, applying the ACA Code of Ethics: B.4.b couples and family counseling, A.1.a primary responsibility, A.4.a avoiding harm, A.4.b personal values, referring to Relevant Laws and Regulations, consulting with colleagues or experts, consider the context, identifying desired outcomes and possible actions to achieve the outcome (having a 1-on-1 conversation with husband while protecting wife's welfare, maintaining therapeutic alliance, and promoting genuine growth), choosing and acting on one's choice by documenting, consulting supervisor, follow protocol, and lastly, reflecting.

The rationale behind my ethical decision-making process was that offering the husband a 1-on-1 conversation gave him the opportunity to take accountability of his actions while also respecting client autonomy and promoting a therapeutic alliance. This decision promotes autonomy, but also has boundaries on what I allow as a therapist in my sessions regarding couples and family counseling and their growth. Giving the husband an opportunity to talk to his wife is also a great way to not cause harm by breaking confidentiality with him. It is also important for the wife to have autonomy and be able to make decisions based on truth rather than manipulation.

Section 3: Reflection

My experience engaging with this ethical decision-making exercise was overwhelming. I was also aware that my past personal experiences could have made this case study challenging. I felt angry while working through this scenario because it brought back feelings of betrayal. Then, I read the wife thanking me for the transformation of her husband without knowing he was having affairs to ease his anger and using it as an unhealthy coping mechanism. I was caught having to pause and think about what was the best ethical route in which my clients would not be compromised, and our therapeutic alliance can continue to grow. I also continued to read the ACA code of ethics, to remind myself it was a professional dilemma and not a personal one. It was important for me to be aware of countertransference and how I could unintentionally harm the counseling journey of my clients.

Now, working through the decision-making process had a lot of emotions involved and a heavy one was feeling anxious. Working through something with no consultation is challenging and leaves a lot of room for acting through emotions rather than logical and following ethical guidelines. Every step had different decisions I could choose from and a different perspective to look at it from, making it difficult for me to not second guess myself. I also had a lot of unanswered questions about whether I was acting upon my past experiences and that I would have wished someone would have told me something. However, working through the case with the ACA code of ethics kept me grounded on my role as a counselor and professionalism. Using the codes helped me separate my emotions and experiences to a professional role. Acknowledging that both clients' autonomy and informed consent matter gave me a sense of confidence in my decision-making process.

Although I am still left with questions and feelings of uncertainty, this exercise taught me how thorough a counselor must be. It also taught me that it is not about having a perfect answer for all scenarios but making an informed and ethical decision with minimal harm to clients. I also learned that some cases could be challenging because of personal experiences which will require me to be self-aware of my biases or limitations and seek supervision when needed. Overall, this was a helpful exercise that helped me understand the complexity of cases and the self-reflection that will be needed throughout my counseling journey in life.